

Gods and Goddesses

Gods and goddesses were believed to be responsible for many aspects of the human experience in the ancient world. The importance of a god was determined by their place in a hierarchical order. The worship of certain gods spread to far-removed places with the expansion of the ancient empires.

Before the spread of some notable “world religions” (see pp.144–47), most people practiced polytheism (see BEFORE). While some of their many gods held sway over a large area, others were gods of a single city or feature in the landscape, such as a river. The deities, who were often depicted with human features, influenced almost every aspect of life. Even the weather was believed to be the result of the current mood of an individual god or goddess.

Social or political changes could influence the way in which godliness was perceived. In times of war and territorial expansion, mortal leaders, such as Roman emperors (see left)



Gods and symbols

This Babylonian is paying his respects to the gods Marduk (symbolized by a triangular-headed spade) and Sin (a crescent moon).

were sometimes worshipped as if they were gods, which served to focus loyalty to that leader. As societies became more complex, the relationships between the gods became more elaborate and many cultures developed a belief in a “pantheon” of gods—gods linked through a hierarchy of power, family ties, and mythological stories. Where cultures made contact, people often related to each other through shared religious links, typically associating gods of similar character. The Roman gods Jupiter and Juno equated with the Greeks’ Zeus and Hera, for instance. For the worshippers, the gods gave omens to those who could interpret them, such as priests,



King of the Persian gods

The two sphinxes on this seal are supporting the winged Ahuramazda, patron god of the Persian monarchy (see pp.92–93). His appearance mirrors that of the king below. Seals transmitted religious images across great distances.

diviners, and oracles. In return the worshippers offered the gods gifts, sacrifice, or ritual tributes to secure their good will.

Supreme gods

In the same way that human societies have leaders, each pantheon also had a “supreme god.” A god was recognized as supreme either by being given prominence by a ruler or city, or by being identified with key symbols in human life, such as a parent, or natural phenomena, such as the sun, sky, ocean, or storms. Gods became supreme gods when people came to think of them as “father” of a family of gods. One such god was Zeus, who was part-father, part-monarch of a quarreling cohort of Greek deities. A god could also be promoted to supreme deity if their city or people became dominant. Bel Marduk, for example, was the patron god of the city of Babylon from about 2000 BCE. When Babylon began

“Men create gods after their own image...”

ARISTOTLE, GREEK PHILOSOPHER, 384–322 BCE

to dominate southern Mesopotamia from 1780 BCE, Marduk’s status was elevated and he acquired family ties with the gods of local regions and cities, eventually becoming supreme.

Gods in the landscape

A wide world of gods was imbued in the landscape itself, although physical evidence of their worship is hard to find, as it can be nothing more than a cluster of plaques by a spring. An ancient description of Persian religion revealed the practice of open-air rituals, and many Persian tablets record gods related to nature. Fertile places were revered across Asia and were the sites of gardens and Buddhist temples. Mountain sanctuaries could be the

MYSTERY RELIGION One of many diverse religious cults involving a belief in death and regeneration or resurrection, which often required personal secret initiation. Early Christianity included many elements of a mystery cult.

focus of cults, such as that devoted to an ancient “Mother of the Gods” on mounts Sipylus and Dindymene in Anatolia. Mountains were sometimes used as billboards to promote a belief. The towering Buddhas in the cliff-face at Bamiyan in Afghanistan were sited strategically to overlook a major road to the East from Rome through Persia.

Migrant gods

Ever-wider cultural interconnections during the 1st millennium CE (see pp.132–33) enabled divine entities, such as the Buddha (see pp.144–47) to spread as never before. Gods could migrate with travelers, soldiers, and merchants across the entire Roman Empire. In London, temples to a rich variety of immigrant gods have been

Zeus’ temple

The 5th century BCE temple of Zeus at Olympia in Greece contains a huge gold- and ivory-covered statue of the supreme god.

From 300 BCE–700 CE, the religious landscape was changed by the spread of the “world religions”—Hinduism, Buddhism, Judaism, Christianity, and Islam.

MONOTHEISM

Within pantheons of gods, lesser deities may diminish and disappear. If only one god remains, people’s beliefs become **monotheistic** 145 >>. Both **Judaism** and the **Zoroastrianism** of Persia have roots in earlier, polytheistic religions.

ENDURING EASTERN BELIEFS

The period 700 BCE–100 CE gave rise to most of today’s established belief systems. In the East, **Taoism**, **Shintoism**, and **Confucianism** << 133 all follow teachings more than 2,000 years old.

UNIVERSAL RELIGION

In antiquity, it was common for people to regard gods as the figureheads of their culture. Their religion was part of their ethnic identity, so it was **not encouraged in foreigners**. In multicultural kingdoms, tolerance of many beliefs was a fact of life. Some new religions, notably **Christianity** 144–47 >> and **Islam** 174–77 >> changed these ideas by proposing that, in theory, all humanity could and should share a single set of religious beliefs and practices.

uncovered. The gods included Serapis, who was first popular with the Greeks of Egypt (see pp.118–19), then hitched a ride with Roman settlement across Europe. Mithras, also worshipped in London, may have begun as the Persian Mithra. Such gods with “exotic” or Eastern origins, often the focus of “Mystery” cults requiring initiation, were popular with the shifting populations of the Roman world.

Exotic god

Dressed in a Phrygian cap and Persian clothing, and slaying a bull in Italy, the exotic origins of Mithras are highlighted in this Roman statue of the 2nd century CE.

